



The Papers on the Table

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Andrew Yates resigned on May 29, 2026, with immediate effect, and Julian McPherson, who ran audit and assurance for KPMG Australia, walked out the same day. Behind those two departures sits a figure the firm cannot resign away: more than \$270 million in federal contracts the Australian government has placed under review. Chairman Martin Sheppard accepted both resignations. The number stays.

2 Picture the room the whistleblower described. Lendlease board papers, confidential, the property of one client, are displayed to KPMG's audit team while the firm is chasing a major audit contract with Westpac. The papers were Lendlease's. The pitch was for Westpac. The team had both in front of it. [Parallelism] KPMG admitted on May 14 that an audit partner had improperly accessed those documents. An audit firm exists to certify that the numbers a company shows the public are true; here the firm could not keep one client's secrets out of its bid to a second.

3 The breach did not stop at Lendlease. The whistleblower alleged that board papers from Dexu and inside information from Macquarie were worked into other tender pursuits, and named two partners, Paul Rogers and Eileen Hoggett, as the leads on the Lendlease account. Senator Deborah O'Neill stood in the Senate on March 24 and laid the allegations out under parliamentary privilege, in the one place a person can name names and not be sued for it. [Ethos] Yates had been chief executive since July 2021, his term reconfirmed by the board in 2024 after an outside review found nothing to fear. The board looked, and missed it.

4 Then the firm investigated itself. The law firm Allens, brought in from outside, found that KPMG's own prior inquiries had "fallen short of the rigour required" to assess what the whistleblower was saying. [Logos] Read plainly, the people charged with checking the work had not checked it. ASIC opened a formal investigation on June 5, and the government pulled its contracts back for review, and Hoggett gave up the chief operating officer title on June 3 but kept her seat as an audit partner. [Polysyndeton] Stan Stavros holds the chief executive chair now, on an interim basis.

5 The firm was hired to verify trust; the firm was caught betraying it. [Antithesis] That is not a story about two careers. The public money under review is your money, routed through a firm the state hired precisely because it was supposed to be the one that does not cut the corner. When the watchdog has to be watched, the duty does not fall back on the regulator alone. It falls on everyone who still has to decide whether the next signed audit means anything at all.

Devices, and why they are here:

Parallelism (paragraph 2): “The papers were Lendlease's. The pitch was for Westpac. The team had both in front of it.”

Three short sentences in the same "The X was Y" frame line the two clients up in matched grammar, so the conflict of interest registers as a pattern the reader sees before any explanation softens it.

Ethos (paragraph 3): “Senator Deborah O'Neill stood in the Senate on March 24 and laid the allegations out under parliamentary privilege, in the one place a person can name names and not be sued for it.”

Locating the disclosure in a named senator speaking under parliamentary privilege borrows the authority and protection of the venue, so the allegations arrive as something put on the public record by a credible office rather than as the writer's claim.

Logos (paragraph 4): “The law firm Allens, brought in from outside, found that KPMG's own prior inquiries had "fallen short of the rigour required" to assess what the whistleblower was saying.”

The author leans on a verifiable outside finding, quoted in KPMG's own commissioned review, so the indictment reads as compelled by evidence rather than asserted, the Reckoning's restraint-as-credibility move.

Polysyndeton (paragraph 4): “ASIC opened a formal investigation on June 5, and the government pulled its contracts back for review, and Hoggett gave up the chief operating officer title on June 3 but kept her seat as an audit partner.”

Chaining the accountability responses with repeated "and" piles the consequences on one another, so the weight of the regulatory and governmental answer accumulates in a single breath rather than landing as a tidy list.

Antithesis (paragraph 5): “The firm was hired to verify trust; the firm was caught betraying it.”

Setting "hired to verify trust" against "caught betraying it" in two balanced clauses sharing the same subject compresses the whole scandal into one symmetrical opposition, naming the moral stake the rest of the piece has been building toward.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the fourth paragraph, the writer presents KPMG's own outside review by the law firm Allens primarily to
 - A) credit the Senate disclosure with prompting the firm to reexamine the case
 - B) concede that KPMG had acted responsibly by investigating the allegations itself
 - C) expose that the firm's earlier inquiries had failed, turning its own finding against it
 - D) establish a neutral chronology of the regulatory steps that followed the resignations
2. Which best characterizes the writer's tone in the final paragraph?
 - A) measured but accusatory, pressing a shared obligation without resorting to name-calling
 - B) detached and clinical, reporting the regulatory steps without taking a position
 - C) resigned and weary, treating the betrayal as an inevitable feature of large firms
 - D) sarcastic and mocking toward the executives who resigned

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer C. The Allens finding that KPMG's prior inquiries "fell short of the rigour required" is deployed as the firm's own evidence against itself, so the move undercuts KPMG's claim to have already examined the allegations. The chronology option is true-but-not-the-function-asked: the regulatory sequence belongs to the ASIC and contract sentence, not to what the Allens finding accomplishes. The concede option inverts the relationship: the finding damns the self-investigation rather than crediting it. The Senate option ties the cause to the wrong span, since the parliamentary disclosure appears in the third paragraph and is not what prompts the Allens review.

2. Answer A. The close charges the reader with a duty ("It falls on everyone") while building the case from fact rather than insult, which is controlled accusation. The detached-and-clinical option inverts the relationship: the paragraph plainly takes a side and addresses the reader directly. The sarcastic option overstates and misreads the register, which indicts through fact, not ridicule. The resigned-and-weary option is the right register at the wrong degree: the close issues an active charge to act, not a shrug that treats the betrayal as inevitable.

Discussion questions:

1. The piece never calls the executives liars or crooks; it builds the indictment almost entirely from dated facts, named bodies, and KPMG's own words. How does that restraint change the force of the accusation compared with direct name-calling?
2. The writer pivots from a single statistic (\$270 million under review) to a scene of board papers on a table and back out to "your money." Why might moving between the large number and the concrete room persuade differently than either one alone?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The restraint makes the charge harder to dismiss. If the writer called Yates a crook, a reader could write the piece off as a hit job and argue about the insult instead of the conduct. Instead the indictment rides on items the reader can check: the May 14 admission, the Allens finding quoted in KPMG's own language, the June 5 ASIC investigation. Because the writer seems forced to the conclusion by the record rather than reaching for it, the accusation reads as conscience rather than attack, which is exactly the posture the Reckoning register depends on.
2. The statistic gives the scandal scale and the scene gives it a face, and the movement between them keeps logic and feeling fused instead of separated. The \$270 million alone is abstract, a number most readers cannot picture. The board papers on the table alone would be a vivid anecdote with no proof it matters beyond one room. By pivoting from the figure to the scene and then out to "your money," the writer makes the reader feel the dollar amount as a personal stake and understand the scene as something larger than a single bad meeting. The pivot is what turns information into obligation.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener turns on a hard claim: that a firm whose entire product is the verification of trust forfeits its standing the moment it is caught using one client's confidences to win another's business, and that the failure is the public's concern, not only the regulator's. Write an essay in which you defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that auditors and similar gatekeeper professions should be held to a higher standard of accountability than ordinary businesses because the public relies on their independence. Use appropriate evidence and reasoning to support your position; you may draw on the opener, on other examples you know, and on your own observation and reading.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may read the three short sentences in paragraph 2 ("The papers were Lendlease's. The pitch was for Westpac. The team had both in front of it.") as a chronological timeline. The marked device is parallelism: the sentences share the same "The X was Y" frame so the two clients line up in matched grammar, set side by side for conflict, not arranged in time. The effect is collision, not sequence.
- Students may label the marked move in paragraph 4 (the Allens finding) as refutation or as the writer simply asserting that KPMG failed. It is logos: the writer leans on a verifiable outside finding, quoted in KPMG's own commissioned review, so the conclusion reads as compelled by evidence rather than claimed. The credibility comes from the cited record, not from the writer's opinion.
- Students may treat the accusatory tone as the writer simply venting anger or mocking the executives. The Reckoning indicts through fact and grammar, not insult; mistaking restraint for ridicule misses how the credibility is built. The accusation is delivered as a shared duty, not a personal attack.
- Students may assume "your money" in the final paragraph is loose exaggeration. It traces to a real fact in the record: more than \$270 million in federal government contracts placed under review, which is public money. The pathos rides on a sourced number, not on an emotional adjective.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches how an argument can indict through evidence and structure rather than invective: students see ethos and logos build prosecutorial force, watch parallelism and antithesis compress a conflict of interest into a few lines, and analyze how a statistic-to-scene pivot fuses logical and emotional appeals. The two reading questions target different skills, one Reasoning and Organization (how the Allens finding functions in the fourth paragraph) and one Style (the tone of the close), and the contestable claim about gatekeeper accountability supports a Q3 argument response.